

DHWANI PATEL

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Scientist-turned-operator with 4+ years designing and running cross-functional operating models for high-ambiguity environments. At CDL-Seattle, owned the venture operating model end-to-end - designing decision rights, operating cadences, and KPI frameworks that aligned founders, VCs, and institutional partners toward measurable outcomes, without direct authority over any of them. Track record of building operational structure from scratch: zero-to-one innovation verticals and recruiting pipelines grown 30% YoY. Brings scientific credibility (PhD, Microbial Genomics) and tool fluency (Salesforce, Airtable, AI automation) to every operating challenge.

CORE COMPETENCIES

Cross-functional Operating Models · Operating Cadence Design · Strategic Program Management · Executive Reporting & KPI Systems · Stakeholder Management Without Authority · Zero-to-One Structure Building · Planning Processes & Decision Rights · Salesforce · Airtable · AI Automation

WORK EXPERIENCE

2021 - 2025 **CREATIVE DESTRUCTION LAB (CDL)** Seattle, WA & Vancouver, BC

Associate Director, Ventures · Strategy, Operations & Ecosystem Programs

Global seed-stage non-profit mentorship program for massively scalable, science- and technology-based startups. Promoted through 4 roles over 4 years: Venture Analyst → Venture Manager → Senior Venture Manager → Associate Director, Ventures. Also held other leadership titles simultaneously (Recruitment Lead, Stream Lead, Apprentice Program Lead).

- Owned CDL-Seattle's venture operating model end-to-end, designing the cross-functional workflows, decision rights, and coordination cadences that aligned founding teams, external stakeholders like VCs and university partners, and internal operating and venture teams toward cohort outcomes
- Built the strategic case for a new innovation vertical (Aging & Longevity) from zero, conducting market analysis across 11+ ventures, synthesizing findings from 10+ key opinion leaders, and delivering the operational plan that was greenlit at the CDL-Seattle site level
- Built evaluation and due diligence workflows for CDL Vancouver's Biomedical Engineering stream and both CDL-Seattle streams (Manufacturing and Computational Health), using Salesforce, Airtable, and AI-assisted systems for KPI tracking, performance metrics, and executive reporting
- Led annual recruiting strategy across CDL Vancouver and CDL-Seattle (2022–2025), developing data-driven sourcing and evaluation frameworks that drove 30% YoY pipeline growth and reached record applications in the 2025 cohort year
- Originated and led two programs from zero: an 83-person industry convening across 10+ partner organizations, and a 71-participant talent development program for female-identifying high school students
- Led a cross-functional venture team of 3–5, setting performance standards, designing training frameworks, and building systems for repeatable founder support and venture evaluation
- Facilitated relationships for 40+ deeptech founders, co-developing bimonthly business development goals across product, GTM strategy, fundraising, and more, contributing to \$32M+ in capital raised (as an example, from the 2023–24 cohort)
- Grew CDL Vancouver's mentor bench 28% by identifying domain coverage gaps, executing a targeted outreach strategy, and onboarding 11 technical and industry leaders, directly expanding the mentorship capital available to founders
- Developed the innovation thesis for CDL Vancouver's Biomedical Engineering stream and CDL-Seattle's Computational Health stream; guided thesis development for CDL-Seattle's Manufacturing stream
- Led the 2023 recruiting and evaluation strategy for CDL Vancouver's BME stream; the cohort reached double its historical graduation rate by year end
- Identified and sourced CDL-Seattle's annual partner ecosystem (cloud, legal, fintech), led initial outreach and discovery conversations, and managed partner benefit distribution across portfolio companies

2020 - 2021 **COMPLETE GENOMICS** Vancouver, BC

Field Application Scientist

Life-science company developing and commercializing proprietary whole-genome sequencing platforms using DNA nanoball (DNBSEQ) and rolling-circle replication technologies.

- Partnered with academic and industry research labs to implement liquid handling, robotics, and genomics sequencing platforms, translating complex technical requirements and gathering scientist feedback to inform product optimization
- Supported the integration of robotics and sequencing workflows across multiple research institutions, enabling the national scale-up of COVID-19 testing infrastructure across Canada

2016 - 2017

UNIVERSITY OF WESTERN AUSTRALIA

Perth, Australia

Research Associate

- Managed \$100K AUD in complex microbiology and plant biotechnology research projects from wet-lab experiment design through data delivery
- Supported \$1M+ AUD in in-house grant-funded initiatives, translating research goals into actionable project plans and managing experiments from inception to completion

EDUCATION

2024	ENTREPRENEURSHIP FINANCE (ENTRE 557)	Foster School of Business, University of Washington
2024	HIGH VELOCITY DEAL-MAKING (MGMT 548)	Foster School of Business, University of Washington
2012 - 2016	PH.D., MICROBIAL GENOMICS	University of Queensland, Brisbane, Australia
2007 - 2011	BACHELOR OF BIOTECHNOLOGY, FIRST CLASS HONOURS	University of Queensland, Brisbane, Australia

SKILLS

- Operations & Analytics:** Salesforce, Airtable (dashboards, automations, formula-based data systems), AI-assisted KPI workflows, cross-functional program delivery, milestone management, executive reporting
- Tools:** Microsoft Suite, G Suite, Slack, Canva, Claude and other AI tools
- Technical Fluency:** Familiar with AI/ML concepts; builds no-code automations and workflows; works across technical and non-technical stakeholders
- Work Authorization:** Eligible for TN (Canadian) and E-3 (Australian) visas